

Chapter 145-1

That evening, Liang Shi went to pick up Xu Qingzhu from work, only to discover that she had left the company to attend a business dinner.

Liang Shi waited downstairs at the company for a long time. She called Xu Qingzhu repeatedly but no one answered, so she called her secretary instead.

Only then did the secretary tell her the location.

The restaurant for the dinner was the same place where Liang Shi had first met Gu Yixue.

She quickly drove there.

Liang Shi sat in the car. The car lights were dim yellow, and the light was somewhat dark.

Outside, the cold wind blew whistling past, while the warm air inside the car made the cramped space feel cozy.

Liang Shi lowered her head to check her phone—the messages she had sent to Xu Qingzhu earlier still hadn't received a response.

When Liang Shi messaged Xu Qingzhu's secretary again, there was no reply either.

She was probably busy.

She kept waiting downstairs until nearly ten o'clock before she finally saw Xu Qingzhu's figure.

A group of people walked out of the building. Xu Qingzhu was dressed thinly, and the wind blew her loose clothing around chaotically. Xu Qingzhu waved goodbye to the others, standing somewhat unsteadily, yet forcing herself to remain composed so that others wouldn't easily notice.

After those people left, only Xu Qingzhu and her secretary remained.

Xu Qingzhu immediately put away all her smiles.

While Xu Qingzhu was talking to her secretary, Liang Shi drove the car over and stopped in front of her.

The car window slowly rolled down, and their eyes met.

Xu Qingzhu was surprised: "Why did you come?"

Liang Shi said gently: "To take you home."

It was as if the argument-like quarrel at noon had never happened.

Perhaps because of the cold wind, Liang Shi's voice carried a hint of coldness. She looked at Xu Qingzhu: "Aren't you cold?"

Xu Qingzhu shivered right on cue, goosebumps rising on the tender white skin of her neck.

She nodded: "I am cold."

After saying this, she looked at Liang Shi with a slightly aggrieved expression: "Aren't you going to come down?"

Liang Shi's hand had already fallen on the car door handle, but after hesitating, she stopped: "You get in the car."

Xu Qingzhu didn't speak, just stared at her unblinkingly.

As if Liang Shi had said something unbelievable.

In truth, no matter how good-tempered a person was, if they were suddenly stood up and then waited like a fool in the car for three hours, they wouldn't be very patient and would be particularly irritated.

During those three hours, Liang Shi's thoughts had gone from: Is she angry? — Should I have said more? — Is she giving me the cold shoulder? — We really need to communicate properly — I don't want to wait anymore — Maybe I should just give her some space and time — What exactly went wrong? — How should I say it?

For nearly three hours, Liang Shi hadn't done anything.

All her time had been spent on these thoughts.

Yet she still couldn't figure it out.

It was like a tangled mess of threads. Liang Shi couldn't find where the end was; she could only face this tangled mess helplessly.

From initially being eager to untangle it to later losing all interest, even wanting to just give up.

So naturally, when she saw Xu Qingzhu, she couldn't act the same as before.

What had happened at noon had also left a knot in her heart. She didn't know what she needed to do to make Xu Qingzhu believe her.

It was clearly so obvious.

And besides, those questions didn't really seem to have much meaning.

It's not like saying "I love you" ten thousand times verbally meant you truly loved someone.

You had to look at what a person actually did.

Moreover, Liang Shi had said those words during those moments of deep emotion.

That was the most sincere expression.

She didn't know what else Xu Qingzhu wanted.

The frustration of not being able to figure things out, combined with the exhaustion of waiting—after wasting time, a person always became particularly cold.

So Liang Shi's voice unconsciously turned cold.

But when she met Xu Qingzhu's pitiful gaze, Liang Shi pressed her lips together.

After struggling internally, she still pushed open the car door and got out.

The cold winter wind blew mercilessly against her, making her instantly alert.

Yet she only looked at Xu Qingzhu.

Their eyes met.

Xu Qingzhu took a step forward toward her, wrapped her arms around her waist, and buried her head in the crook of her shoulder.

Chapter 145-2

"Wifey."¹ Xu Qingzhu's voice was very soft, her tone gentle, carrying an indescribable sense of grievance. "I missed you so much."

Liang Shi: "....."

Just a moment ago, Liang Shi had briefly considered giving her the cold shoulder, but at this moment, all her coldness completely crumbled.

Liang Shi's arms, which had been hanging at her sides, reached out to hold Xu Qingzhu tightly. Cold wind swirled around them, blowing wildly.

Xu Qingzhu sobbed with grievance: "I drank so much wine. I missed you."

Liang Shi stroked her slender back, her long hair tangling between Liang Shi's fingers.

"Wifey." Xu Qingzhu's voice was choked with emotion. "Please don't be angry with me... I really didn't mean to say those things."

Liang Shi could smell a strong scent of alcohol.

It seemed Xu Qingzhu had drunk quite a lot—she couldn't even speak clearly, and by the end, her body was trembling badly.

Hearing her say this, Liang Shi also felt her heart ache: "I'm not angry with you."

Xu Qingzhu's eyelashes brushed against the skin of Liang Shi's neck: "I'm sorry, wifey."

This wasn't the first time Xu Qingzhu had called her "wifey."

It's just that when she usually said it, it was mostly teasing, or when she was being bullied too hard in bed, she would cry out: "Wifey, be gentler..."

If Liang Shi stopped, she would then say pitifully: "Wifey, it feels so uncomfortable."

These were all things that generally only happened during her heat period.

When she was properly sober, Xu Qingzhu never called her that. She usually called her Teacher Liang, Liang Shi, or occasionally called her "jiejie"² in a flirtatious manner.

But today, she used such a grieved tone, her voice drawing out at the end—it was heart-wrenching to hear.

Liang Shi patted her back: "It's okay, I'm really not angry with you."

That afternoon, Liang Shi had also been reflecting on whether she hadn't done well enough.

It's just that the more than three hours of waiting had put her in a somewhat unpleasant mood.

When she first saw Xu Qingzhu, she didn't feel as fond of her as before.

But the moment Xu Qingzhu looked at her with those eyes, all of Liang Shi's rationality and resistance crumbled completely.

Her wife was standing right in front of her looking so aggrieved, and she was just going to coldly stand by and ignore her?

Liang Shi couldn't do it.

Xu Qingzhu wrapped her arms around her neck, her warm breath from speaking landing on Liang Shi's skin: "Wifey... please don't be angry, okay?"

Liang Shi patiently explained to her again: "I'm not angry with you."

Meanwhile, the secretary standing not far away holding Xu Qingzhu's coat was so shocked her jaw practically dropped.

Th-th-th-this... was this the President Xu she knew?

Her image had completely collapsed, just like that, in an instant.

Footnotes:

¹ "Wifey" (老婆, lǎo pó): A Chinese term of endearment used between spouses or romantic partners, equivalent to "wife" or "wifey" in English. It's an intimate and affectionate way to address one's partner.

² "Jiejie" (姐姐): Literally means "older sister" in Chinese, but is also commonly used as a flirtatious or affectionate term of address toward an older woman one is close to or romantically interested in.

Chapter 145-3

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After getting drunk, Xu Qingzhu couldn't even wait until they got home—she fell asleep in the car.

Yet strangely enough, she woke up as soon as Liang Shi parked. She forced herself to stay alert and went upstairs with Liang Shi to go home.

The moment they entered, Xu Qingzhu wanted Liang Shi to hold her.

She leaned against the door, hanging on Liang Shi like she had no bones.

Liang Shi held her tight and called out softly: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu was stunned for a moment: "Huh?"

She frowned: "Wifey..."

With a hint of resentment.

Liang Shi responded: "Mm?"

Xu Qingzhu cupped her face with both hands, staring at her very seriously, as if trying to see right through her.

Being stared at like this, even though Liang Shi was sober, she felt both embarrassed and moved. She really wanted to kiss those glistening lips.

"Wifey~" Xu Qingzhu called out to her coquettishly.

"I'm here." Liang Shi's response came naturally now, though her heart was pounding wildly.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers brushed across her throat, her gaze fixed directly on her. Under the dim yellow light, she looked gentle and beautiful.

Xu Qingzhu acted spoiled: "Call me that too~"

Liang Shi's throat moved slightly under her fingers.

After a moment, in the quiet stillness, Liang Shi spoke: "Wifey."

Under Xu Qingzhu's gaze like this, Liang Shi's voice still came out somewhat stiff.

Xu Qingzhu frowned with dissatisfaction: "Can you say it again?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She didn't know why Xu Qingzhu was so fixated on this term of endearment, but she still satisfied her request.

The second time was a bit softer than the first.

"Still not enough." Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up. "One more time."

Liang Shi was a bit embarrassed. Seeing that Xu Qingzhu had gone so soft she was about to slide down, her hand fell to her waist, scooping her up a bit, her palm resting on her waist.

"You've had too much to drink." Liang Shi cleared her throat lightly. "Let me help you go rest."

"No!" Xu Qingzhu suddenly became serious. "I want to hear you talk."

"Say what?" Liang Shi asked.

"Call me wifey." Xu Qingzhu said. "The kind where you say it with lots and lots of love."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, not knowing why Xu Qingzhu had suddenly become like this, as if she had become a different person.

"Go lie down on the bed." Liang Shi said. "I'll go make you some honey water, otherwise you'll have a headache tomorrow morning."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No..."

"Wifey." Liang Shi tried coaxing her gently. "Won't you go rest?"

Just like coaxing a child.

But Xu Qingzhu continued shaking her head: "That's not how it should be. It needs to be in a very sweet, very sweet tone, looking very, very doting... Wifey..."

As Xu Qingzhu said this, she was on the verge of tears herself. She furrowed her brow, tears pooling in her eyes: "Won't you call me that?"

Liang Shi immediately stroked her back gently, trying to soothe her emotions.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked. "Did something happen?"

"Nothing happened to me." Xu Qingzhu was somewhat agitated. Tears fell like pearls, pattering down as she whimpered: "As expected, when there's no mission, you won't even cooperate with me."

Mission?

Liang Shi was startled: "What do you mean?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, her voice still trembling: "You coax me every day, stay with me, make me happy—isn't it all for the mission? But... I really like you so much."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes were red like a little rabbit's: "I like you so much... so much... Wifey~ you..."

Xu Qingzhu coughed as she spoke, then said in a hoarse voice, almost pleading: "Even if you're just going through the motions with me, can't you at least be more sincere about it?"

"I'm not going through the motions with you." Liang Shi was shocked by her words. For a moment, she didn't know where to begin explaining, but she immediately said: "I don't like you because of some mission."

"Wifey." Xu Qingzhu hugged her tightly, burying her head in the crook of her shoulder. The arms wrapped around her waist tightened in an instant—so tight that Liang Shi could barely breathe.

Xu Qingzhu's tears fell on her neck: "Even if it's to deceive me, please don't tell me, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu's voice trembled: "Just keep deceiving me for a long, long time."

"I'm not deceiving you." Liang Shi's heart was breaking listening to this. Xu Qingzhu's voice was terribly hoarse, yet she still pleaded in a muffled voice: "Can't you love me more? Even if it's a lie, say you love me more."

"That way I won't feel so awful." Xu Qingzhu said. "My heart hurts so much right now."

"Wifey." Liang Shi called out to her softly, tender and affectionate. "I'm not lying to you. I never have been, from start to finish."

"I do love you." Liang Shi said. "I really do."

"I love you so, so much." Liang Shi assured her. "I love you so much. Please don't cry."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled: "Mm, even if you're lying to me, keep lying to me like this."

Without waiting for Liang Shi to explain, she kissed her directly on the lips.